

Hick's Law

What is it?

Decision-making becomes harder when there are too many choices. Fewer options help people decide faster and with more confidence.

History

Named after psychologists William Edmund Hick and Ray Hyman in **1952**, who discovered that decision time increases as the number of choices increases. More options create more processing time, slowing down the brain.

The Psychology Behind It

- More choices increase cognitive load
- People hesitate longer when evaluating many alternatives
- Too many choices can lead to decision paralysis
- Simplifying choices reduces mental effort and speeds up action

Why It Matters

- Decision fatigue
- Lower conversions
- Higher bounce rates
- Frustrated users abandoning tasks

How to Apply It

- Limit the number of visible options
- Highlight recommended / most popular choices
- Use default settings to guide faster selection
- Simplify screens and flows to reduce overload

Theory in Action

- Netflix shows personalized top picks to reduce choice overload
- Fast food menus simplify ordering with “combos” and “best sellers”

Final Thought

Fewer choices make decisions faster and easier. Designers who simplify choices reduce friction and help users act with confidence.

